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Security Council

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New York

President:	Mrs. Rodrigues-Birkett	(Guyana)
Members:	Algeria	Mr. Yahiaoui
	China	Mr. Geng Shuang
	Denmark	Ms. Lassen
	France	Mr. Bonnafont
	Greece	Mr. Sekeris
	Pakistan	Mr. Ahmad
	Panama	Mr. Alfaro de Alba
	Republic of Korea	Mr. Hwang
	Russian Federation	Mr. Nebenzia
	Sierra Leone	Mr. Totangi
	Slovenia	Mrs. Blokar Drobič
	Somalia	Mr. Abdullahi Ali Yusuf
	United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland	Mr. Kariuki
	United States of America	Ms. Shea

Agenda

The situation in Afghanistan

Report of the Secretary-General on the situation in Afghanistan and its implications for international peace and security (S/2025/372)

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The meeting was called to order at 10.05 a.m.

Adoption of the agenda

The agenda was adopted.

The situation in Afghanistan

Report of the Secretary-General on the situation in Afghanistan and its implications for international peace and security (S/2025/372)

The President: In accordance with rule 37 of the Council's provisional rules of procedure, I invite the representatives of Afghanistan, India, the Islamic Republic of Iran and Qatar to participate in this meeting.

In accordance with rule 39 of the Council's provisional rules of procedure, I invite the following briefers to participate in this meeting: Ms. Roza Otunbayeva, Special Representative of the Secretary-General and Head of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan; Ms. Joyce Msuya, Assistant Secretary-General for Humanitarian Affairs and Deputy Emergency Relief Coordinator; and Ms. Sima Sami Bahous, Executive Director of UN-Women.

The Security Council will now begin its consideration of the item on its agenda.

I wish to draw the attention of Council members to document S/2025/372, which contains the report of the Secretary-General on the situation in Afghanistan and its implications for international peace and security.

I now give the floor to Ms. Otunbayeva.

Ms. Otunbayeva: Upon the guidance of the Security Council, and on the basis of the November 2023 independent assessment (S/2023/856, annex), the United Nations has sought to create a framework for more coherent, coordinated and structured engagement with Afghanistan's de facto authorities. The objective is engagement with a clear goal: an end state of an Afghanistan at peace with itself and its neighbours, fully reintegrated into the international community and meeting its international obligations, without going through another cycle of violence.

The comprehensive approach the United Nations proposes for this new chapter of engagement is for the benefit of the Afghan people. They suffered four decades of war and have now been suffering in a different way for nearly four years. The comprehensive approach involves working groups and a mosaic of key issues. I stress that the approach does not seek to normalize the status quo, but rather ensure that multiple key issues of concern, in particular upholding the country's international obligations, remain at the core of engagement efforts.

Questions have been raised about the results of the engagement thus far. According to the results of our extensive outreach and many interactions with Afghans across the country, it is their view that both Afghans and the country would be in a far worse place without the presence and assistance of the international community. At the very least, the international presence provides an element of protection and prevention. The Afghan people remain hopeful that their country can be reintegrated into the international system and that outstanding issues can be solved through diplomacy. At the same time, the international community remains extremely concerned that engagement has not improved the unacceptable situation of Afghan women and girls, promoted inclusive governance or prevented a marked deterioration in human rights. The de facto authorities also convey their grievances: frozen assets, sanctions, non-recognition, the need for development assistance and an end to aid dependency.

Through the comprehensive approach, the United Nations seeks to put these issues into a more structured multilateral framework for dialogue and potential progress. It seeks to demonstrate to the de facto authorities and to Afghans that there is a pathway to reintegration; to describe in more detail the steps that are necessary for reintegration; to maintain open channels for discussion and possible international cooperation; and, through the building of confidence, begin removing obstacles that impede further cooperation. The aim is to provide a framework and process that highlights the potential benefits of global cooperation, paving the way for these challenges to be more effectively addressed.

In doing so, we have engaged with multiple stakeholders inside and outside of Afghanistan, not only to build a consensus, but to also ensure this is a process through which all voices will be heard. In a few days in Doha, the United Nations is convening meetings of the two working groups on counter-narcotics and the private sector — established following the third meeting of special envoys, held in Doha in 2024 — that bring all stakeholders together at the same table. This is an important development that gives momentum to multilateral engagement and builds confidence in the value of mutual cooperation in the crucial areas of enabling the private sector and counter-narcotics.

The de facto authorities have provided relative stability and security, promoted modest economic growth and foreign investment, initiated dormant infrastructure projects and deepened their diplomatic ties abroad, especially within the region. But they also continue to implement highly restrictive and discriminatory policies on the Afghan people. Those policies are embodied in the Law on the Propagation of Virtue and the Prevention of Vice, promulgated last August. In April, The United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) released a report on the law's implementation and impact on the Afghan people.

In addition to its human rights implications for Afghan women and men, the law has far-reaching impacts for Afghanistan's minorities; for the economy, particularly women-run businesses; for humanitarian operations; and for the media. The law cemented the de facto authorities' systematic, State-sponsored policies that exclude women and girls from participation in public life, including access to education, employment, freedom of movement and freedom of expression.

Through that law, the de facto authorities are continuing to pursue a path that distances Afghanistan from its international obligations and hinders Afghanistan's eventual reintegration into the international system.

We cannot forget the unacceptable situation of Afghan women and girls, even if their continued marginalization under the increased enforcement of more and more decrees no longer generates headlines. As one Afghan woman interlocutor said to us, the current struggle is not about dramatic acts of defiance but the quiet and relentless pursuit of daily life — of resilience. She urged the international community to look beyond sensational headlines and recognize that what is happening is an invisible war of attrition in which survival itself is an act of rebellion.

The ongoing ban on girls' education beyond the primary level is the clearest sign of the Taliban's discrimination against women and continues to set Afghanistan apart from the world. We call again for that ban to be lifted and for girls and women to be allowed once again the right to education.

Freedom of expression and the space for private media in Afghanistan have shrunk further. The de facto authorities continued to use arbitrary arrests and detentions to stifle opposition voices.

I am pleased to report on constructive engagement with the de facto Office of Prison Administration. We have received commitments concerning continued access

to prisons and male and female detainees countrywide, and on addressing issues and improving the conditions for detainees within their means. I welcome those efforts, for instance, on vocational training sessions, limited mental health support and food support in some prisons.

The delivery of UNAMA's mandate is also complex and sometimes dangerous. In May, dozens of our female national staff were subjected to explicit death threats from unidentified individuals in relation to their work with UNAMA and other United Nations agencies, funds and programmes, requiring us to implement interim measures to protect their safety. In our subsequent engagements with the de facto authorities, they said they were not responsible, but it was also clear that those armed individuals were operating with impunity in a coordinated manner in the capital. That strongly undermines the de facto authorities' claim that they have established security and secured the safety and dignity of Afghan women.

In general, the number of security incidents has remained low. However, at the same time, countries of the region continue to express concerns about the presence of the Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan (ISIL-K) in Afghanistan, as well as other groups of foreign fighters that could pose a threat to the region.

This reporting period has witnessed the longest hiatus in ISIL-K operations in Afghanistan since the Taliban takeover in August 2021. The threat remains present, however. The de facto authorities continue to repeat their stated policy that they will not allow foreign terrorist groups to use Afghan territory to threaten other countries. Nevertheless, Member States have reasons to remain concerned, as the Sanctions Monitoring Team has reported.

Another area of our mandate that is becoming increasingly challenging to implement is humanitarian mine action. Over the years, United Nations coordination and threat mitigation work has helped to save countless civilian lives from the scourge of the explosive remnants of war, mainly children's lives. The funding available to United Nations partners for that critical work ends in July. Key data management informing of which areas have been made safe will halt. Crucial quality assurance and prioritization work will stop. And without United Nations coordination, mine action non-governmental organizations will be working in isolation, and contamination and clearance data will not be available to other humanitarian and development actors. Compared to only a year ago, the number of mine action teams active in the field has already nearly halved. Mines and unexploded ordnance have killed hundreds of people this year, most of them children, and if the current funding cuts continue, countless more lives will be at risk. The grim picture of demining work in Afghanistan reflects broader cuts in life-saving humanitarian assistance to the people of Afghanistan.

Almost midway through the year, the humanitarian needs and response plan for Afghanistan is only 19 per cent funded. That shortfall — which has been compounded by recent dramatic cuts in donor funding — jeopardizes the humanitarian response at a time when the region is experiencing considerable volatility.

Already, more than 600,000 Afghans have returned from neighbouring Pakistan and the Islamic Republic of Iran this year. Given the concerning developments in the region, the United Nations agencies are preparing for potential cross-border movement from Iran. Returns from Iran alone in the past few days have numbered more than 10,000 people per day. Communities and the de facto authorities have made huge efforts to absorb returnees, but without international assistance, there are limits to safe, orderly and peaceful returns.

Let me conclude by echoing the Secretary-General's calls for immediate de-escalation in the conflict between Israel and Iran. That conflict is already having an effect in Afghanistan, disrupting trade and increasing the prices of basic goods

and fuel, and prompting the return of additional Afghans from Iran. The current challenges are significant enough. They will be made worse with regional instability.

The President: I thank Ms. Otunbayeva for her briefing.

I now give the floor to Ms. Msuya.

Ms. Msuya: I will build upon the words of my colleague, the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan, Roza Otunbayeva, on the humanitarian situation.

The people of Afghanistan face persistent and acute humanitarian needs, compounded by decades of conflict, entrenched poverty, an ever-harsher climate, severe restrictions on the rights of women and girls and a highly constrained funding environment. Faced with hunger, protracted displacement and limited access to essential services, half of the population needs humanitarian assistance.

While words often fall short, the numbers speak with clarity. One in every five Afghans is hungry, and 3.5 million children are acutely malnourished. An estimated 3.7 million children are out of school, including 2.2 million girls over the age of 11 who have been banned from education by restrictions imposed by the de facto authorities. The maternal mortality rate is more than 2.5 times the global average. More than 600,000 Afghans have returned from Iran and Pakistan this year, including many women, even as resources are scarce and services are struggling to cope. Parts of the country stand on the cusp of drought once again, for the fourth time in just five years. Kabul risks becoming the first city in modern times to run out of water, as water levels within its aquifers have dropped by up to 30 metres in the past decade as a result of urbanization and climate change. Almost half of the city's boreholes have dried out.

The United Nations and partners are doing their best to stave off the worst impacts of climate shocks, including with a $16.6 million allocation from the Central Emergency Response Fund in April by the Emergency Relief Coordinator. Funding cuts continue to hinder the humanitarian response. Owing to a lack of funding, 420 health facilities have been forced shut, depriving more than 3 million Afghans of life-saving health services. Almost 300 nutrition sites have closed, depriving 80,000 acutely malnourished children, pregnant women and new mothers of essential treatment. The impacts of cuts were the harsh reality for the women and healthcare workers that the Emergency Relief Coordinator met in Kabul, Kandahar and Kunduz during his visit in April.

Since the Taliban took power almost four years ago this August, Afghan women and girls have borne the worst impacts of the crisis. The United Nations and its partners have consistently advocated for the participation of Afghan women in the humanitarian response. As we heard from Special Representative of the Secretary-General Otunbayeva, their ability to work freely, without harassment, intimidation or the threat of violence must be restored urgently. We renew our call for them to be allowed to work safely and without restriction.

Despite challenges and at great risk, our Afghan female colleagues continue to deliver aid, going where others cannot, listening to communities that would otherwise not be heard and standing by those who might otherwise be forgotten. In support of local partnerships, the Afghanistan Humanitarian Fund recently launched a $2.4 million allocation dedicated entirely to national actors, including 18 women-led organizations.

This is the seventh briefing by the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA) to the Council since the adoption of the humanitarian exception in resolution 2615 (2021). As we have previously shared with the Council, resolution 2615 (2021) is vital to life-saving humanitarian action in Afghanistan. Since

15 August 2021, $7.8 billion in humanitarian funding have allowed us to help the most vulnerable people in Afghanistan. That funding has saved countless lives, reducing the number of those experiencing food insecurity, providing essential health services and supporting people affected by displacement, earthquakes, droughts and floods.

Those achievements have been possible because the humanitarian exception covers expenditures that are necessary to deliver humanitarian assistance. That includes rent on State-owned premises and warehouses; withholding tax on national and international non-governmental organization (NGO) staff income, rent and suppliers; fees for visas and work permits for national and international NGO staff; fees for imports; the cost of utilities, such as water and electricity; and the cost of licences for NGO registration and communications equipment and municipal charges.

The nature and modality of payments made under the exception have remained unchanged over the past four years. They are the same payments and modalities carried out before August 2021, under the previous Administration of the Islamic Republic of Afghanistan. Those expenses are essential, planned and budgeted operational costs, critical to carrying out humanitarian assistance across Afghanistan. They are in line with payments that we have to make to authorities in every country in which humanitarian assistance is implemented.

In an environment as complex as Afghanistan, risks may manifest themselves through attempts to interfere with aid distribution or pressures to amend beneficiary lists. Risks apply to both in-kind and cash programming. Humanitarians make every effort to ensure that aid reaches the people who need it. Steps are taken to prevent diversion, including in the assessment, planning, distribution and monitoring phases, applying standards in line with best practices. In-kind and cash assistance is allocated on the basis of rigorous needs and vulnerability assessments and governed by clearly defined criteria, with distributions safeguarded by vetted beneficiary lists, identification checks and biometric authentication and reinforced by in-person monitoring.

This past year, we strengthened our risk management procedures. A risk mitigation matrix is regularly reviewed, and a risk register is updated to identify and address potential aid diversion channels. Monthly post-distribution monitoring exercises assess indicators to detect irregularities in cash assistance, including aid diversion. To minimize risks even further, some humanitarian partners have also digitized the payment process from source to beneficiary. OCHA has delivered training on the risks of aid diversion in cash and voucher assistance, reaching staff across more than 50 organizations.

Financial service providers engaged by humanitarian partners for aid distribution also undergo rigorous due diligence. Measures include a detailed vetting for all suppliers and partners, with annual rescreening and contractual clauses to ensure compliance, including termination clauses when sanction breaches are identified. If aid diversion ever does occur, we take action by ceasing distributions, engaging with entities at the central and regional levels, establishing compliance criteria for the resumption of aid and ensuring that donors are informed.

The high levels of needs in Afghanistan outpace the funding available to support people. We are halfway through the year, and the humanitarian response plan is funded at less than 21 per cent, with a gap of $1.9 billion. Owing to cuts, we have hyperprioritized the response to focus on the most critical needs of 12.5 million people in the most severely affected districts, down from an initial target of 16.8 million people. We had to deprioritize lower-severity areas, not because needs have disappeared, but because resources are not enough. Our response has continued, but our ability to reach those in need has diminished.

Cuts have had a particular impact on support for women. Organizations are finding it more difficult to bear mahram costs when women need to be escorted by men when traveling and other costs related to sharia-compliant employment of women. Reduced movement results in reduced reach, such as basic health services for women. To mitigate the impact of reduced resources, humanitarian partners in Afghanistan are implementing an ambitious reform of the coordination architecture. In line with the humanitarian reset, it will further enhance efficiencies, accountability and impact.

For the people of Afghanistan, allow me to conclude with three asks.

The first is a continued strengthening of the implementation of the humanitarian exception in resolution 2615 (2021).

The second is support for the resilience of Afghan communities by increasing investments in agriculture, health systems and other vital services. The humanitarian response alone will never fully address the scale of what is required.

The third is for our humanitarian work to be funded.

The needs of the Afghan people must not be forgotten.

The President: I thank Ms. Msuya for her briefing.

I now give the floor to Ms. Bahous.

Ms. Bahous: I thank you, Madam President, for inviting me to brief.

Let me begin by commending the Council for the unity that it displayed in March in renewing the mandate of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan, which included recognizing the fundamental rights of women and reaffirming their indispensable role in society (see S/PV.9880). Peace, stability and prosperity in Afghanistan will be possible only with the realization of the full rights and freedoms of its women and girls.

We meet at a time when global peace is elusive and hope is fragile. The recent escalation in the Middle East, including in Iran — home to more than 3 million Afghan refugees — has intensified regional and global instability. The growing regional and global insecurity will only deepen the hardships faced by Afghan women and girls, compounding poverty, displacement, violence and deprivation. They — and all women and girls everywhere — deserve peace. I echo all calls to choose diplomacy, to de-escalate and to respect international law and the Charter of the United Nations.

Since I briefed the Council on Afghanistan nine months ago (see S/PV.9726), the reality for Afghan women and girls has only grown more dire. Not a single restriction has been reversed. Repression has become more systematic and has calcified into structure and law. Amid this deepening crisis, Afghan women's call for the world not to forget about them is too often unheard. With the many geopolitical shifts, the growing global instability and the multiple humanitarian crises with which the world is grappling, our attention drifts, returning to them only when the next ban is announced, while their lives are growing more constrained.

Despite multiple Council resolutions demanding safe and unhindered access for female aid workers, the ability of the United Nations and our partners to deliver for Afghan women has been drastically undermined. Legal and bureaucratic barriers imposed by the de facto authorities make it harder than ever to hire women safely or to even reach them, all while deep funding cuts are having ever more devastating consequences. Yet we stay and we deliver, as we always have. With the United Nations country team, UN-Women continues to do its utmost to support Afghan women in navigating through endless restrictions. We provide for separate facilities

and for male chaperones, the mahrams, and we are constantly negotiating with the de facto authorities for exceptions.

And Afghan women continue to lead the way. They have opened underground schools, organized in silence, built lives in those slivers of space left to them. They have shown unshakable determination, even when the world faltered. The story of Sama, a woman in Bamiyan who runs a small shop in the women's entrepreneur market, is one of courage and inspiration. With solar panels installed by UN-Women, she and other women entrepreneurs have saved money on electricity, increased product outputs and expanded their investments. In just one year, 35 women-led businesses in the market in Bamiyan collectively earned more than $62,500 in revenue — more than twice their previous annual income. That is resilience and that is hope and resolve, even in the darkest of times.

While Sama's story is a pocket of light, the reality remains that a third of the population, mostly women and children, face malnutrition, even starvation at times, as the price of basic staples has surged. Hundreds of clinics have closed. Midwives are reporting a rise in maternal deaths. Mental health issues are on the rise. Girls are losing access to food, education and any vision for their futures. Child marriage and teenage pregnancies are on the rise. The narrow window of a sixth-grade education for girls is narrowing. Some girls are now praying to fail their exams simply to remain in school a little longer. Others are never sent to school at all. Why invest in hope when hope is banned? Meanwhile, Afghan boys are growing up in a system that teaches them that women are inferior. This is not just a crisis for girls. This is generational damage.

We can only try to grasp what this means for the millions of girls forced to endure that reality. The latest data from UN-Women's "Gender Index 2024: Afghanistan", launched last week, confirms a grim trajectory. Nearly 78 per cent of Afghan women aged 18 to 29 are neither working, nor studying, nor training, making Afghanistan home to one of the widest and fastest-growing gender gaps in the world. Men are nearly three times more likely than women to own a bank account or to use mobile money services. Rates of intimate partner violence are rising, and it is estimated that education bans alone will cost Afghanistan $1.5 billion by 2030. While it has been nearly four years, it is still difficult to comprehend the speed and scale of the rollback, how swiftly women's rights were erased and how comprehensively their presence was removed from public life. Allow me to offer Council members four recommendations.

First, in all our engagements with the Taliban, we must put in place measures that do not unintentionally support or normalize the Taliban's discriminatory policies, norms and values. Those include the discussions on structured engagement with the Taliban through the Doha process, the mosaic approach or other international forums. Afghan women must not be relegated to the margins. The legitimacy and sustainability of any outcome depend on Afghan women's meaningful, safe, full and equal participation. Member States represented here today can commit to gender parity in all diplomatic engagement with the de facto authorities.

Secondly, we urge the Council to actively support ongoing accountability efforts. Earlier this month, the Special Rapporteur on the situation of human rights in Afghanistan, released a sobering report on the severe barriers that Afghan women and girls face in accessing justice and protection. The report reinforces the urgency of establishing an independent accountability mechanism with a comprehensive mandate to investigate and document violations. The Council also has the tools and the responsibility to act decisively through its own mechanisms. The Security Council Committee established pursuant to resolution 1988 (2011) could convene a dedicated session focused on violations of women's rights in Afghanistan and consider expanding its listing criteria to include such violations.

Thirdly, donors must commit resources. The significant burdens that funding cuts are bringing to the response in Afghanistan require us more than ever to hold a principled line in ensuring Afghan women and girls are protected and empowered. At least 30 per cent of all financial assistance to Afghanistan should directly support women and girls. Financial assistance should be channelled to women-led, grassroots organizations; those that are at the front lines of the response, already doing the impossible and reaching women and girls where no one else can.

Fourthly, investing in digital literacy for Afghan women and girls is crucial. Digital means are often the only way to access education, training or counselling. And digital literacy and access can support the expansion and growth of Afghan women's businesses.

In conclusion, Afghan women have not given up, nor can we. We must not look away. We must not grow used to their situation. The systematic oppression of 20 million people simply because they are women is utterly unacceptable.

The Council has repeatedly called for women's full, equal and meaningful participation, including in decisions concerning Afghanistan. That call can become action through the ways in which the Taliban is engaged, through the measures for accountability the Council puts in place and by ensuring that our commitments are matched by the financial resources required.

There is no justification for delay. I urge us all to spare no effort in living up to the promises made to the women and girls of Afghanistan.

The President: I thank Ms. Bahous for her briefing.

I shall now give the floor to those members of the Council who wish to make statements.

Mrs. Blokar Drobič (Slovenia): I wish to add my thanks to Special Representative of the Secretary-General Otunbayeva, Assistant Secretary-General Msuya and Executive Director Bahous for their briefings.

I wish to begin by stressing the importance of the work of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA), in particular in the fields of human rights and humanitarian assistance. We appreciate UNAMA's continued engagement with Afghan and international stakeholders. Its presence in Afghanistan remains essential.

We welcome the most recent periodic report of the Secretary-General (S/2025/372), as well as UNAMA's special report on the implementation, enforcement and impact of the so-called Law on the Propagation of Virtue and the Prevention of Vice. Eight months into its enforcement, women, minorities, children, men, youth and older persons across Afghanistan have been negatively impacted to varying degrees. It has further restricted the rights of women and girls, who bear the brunt of its impact. It is the fourth consecutive school year in which women and girls are excluded from education beyond the sixth grade. That continued exclusion remains deeply concerning.

We reiterate our call for the Taliban to reverse those unacceptable discriminatory policies and practices. Any country's strength lies in recognizing and upholding the inherent equality of all its people. The Taliban must ensure that their domestic and foreign policies serve the entire population. Among others, the direct and indirect socioeconomic consequences of the law are likely to worsen Afghanistan's already dire economic and humanitarian situation. Such human rights violations also inevitably weaken long-term stability and security.

The exclusion of women and girls from education and employment has a much wider impact than on one person; it deprives families of their income, deepens

their poverty and triggers or contributes to forced migration. We continue to call for inclusivity and good, effective and accountable governance and for full, equal, meaningful and safe participation of women and girls in all spheres of societal and public life and for the authorities to uphold their right to education, healthcare, employment and work, as well as their freedom of movement, expression and peaceful assembly.

The Taliban and the international community have yet to establish the trust necessary to address the needs and aspirations of Afghanistan's diverse population. In that regard, we note the developments within the working groups on counter-narcotics and the private sector, both of which are important for addressing issues that are critically relevant to the livelihoods of Afghans.

We continue to support coherent and structured engagement with the Taliban to comprehensively address the complex challenges that stand between Afghanistan's current situation and the aspirations for reintegration into the international community. What must be clear, however, is that progress depends on the Taliban demonstrating both willingness and an understanding of their international obligations to bring the process further. We are of the view that no solution to many challenges faced by Afghanistan will be sustainable without addressing the issue of equal enjoyment of human rights.

We reiterate our strong support for a democratic and prosperous future for Afghanistan, one in which the country is at peace with itself and its neighbours and fully integrated into the international community. We envision an Afghanistan capable of fulfilling the obligations of a sovereign State, both to its own population, as well as in relation to other States.

The lasting crisis continues to generate humanitarian needs unparalleled in scale, severity and complexity, now increasingly compounded by often forcible deportations of Afghans from neighbouring States, climate shocks and extreme weather events. The unrelenting pressure of the humanitarian crisis has profound repercussions for the overall stability of Afghanistan.

In conclusion, let me reiterate that all humanitarian actors, including female humanitarian staff, need safe and unhindered access to provide urgent assistance to the affected population without discrimination and in line with humanitarian principles.

Ms. Shea (United States of America): I thank Special Representative of the Secretary-General Roza Otunbayeva, Assistant Secretary-General Joyce Msuya and Executive Director of UN-Women Sima Sami Bahous for their informative briefings, and I welcome the representative of Afghanistan.

It has been nearly four years since the Taliban takeover in Afghanistan, and the situation remains dire. The people of Afghanistan continue to suffer from multiple challenges, including poverty, unemployment, limited access to basic services and natural disasters, all made worse by the Taliban's oppressive policies.

As we reflect on the past four years, our approach to assistance has not been sustainable and has failed to yield the intended results. We continue to have the same conversations without demanding results from the Taliban.

The United States Afghanistan policy is currently under review. However, President Trump and Secretary Rubio have made clear that our focus in Afghanistan has narrowed. Protecting United States citizens, including mitigating terrorist threats, and securing the release of all detained Americans are our top priorities in Afghanistan.

The Trump Administration has already proven itself to be pragmatic in just its first few months, prioritizing actions over words.

For decades, the United States sacrificed American lives and billions of dollars to support the people of Afghanistan. Many of the countries represented in this Chamber have done the same. It is now time for the Taliban to perform.

It is in our mutual interest to ensure that Afghanistan never again harbours terrorists, does not engage in hostage diplomacy and is a net contributor to regional stability, rather than a detractor.

It is time for change to come from within Afghanistan. I hope our joint approach can bring about more effective outcomes in Afghanistan.

Mr. Kariuki (United Kingdom): I thank Special Representative of the Secretary-General Otunbayeva, Assistant Secretary-General Msuya and Executive Director Bahous for their briefings today. We commend the tireless work of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan, the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs and UN-Women in support of the people of Afghanistan.

Since our last Council briefing on Afghanistan (see S/PV.9875), another school year has begun with secondary schools and higher education remaining closed to women and girls. It is now more than three years since the Taliban's edict denying them their right to education. The United Kingdom continues to unequivocally condemn that ban and urges its immediate reversal.

Education is not the only sector from which half of Afghanistan's population is barred. We remain deeply concerned by the Taliban's short-sighted ban on women's medical education and by the challenges Afghan women and girls face in accessing life-saving healthcare, including sexual and reproductive health services. As we heard from Ms. Bahous, nearly 8 in 10 young Afghan women are excluded from education, employment and training opportunities.

It is unacceptable that the Taliban's restrictive edicts deny Afghan women and girls their rights and fundamental freedoms. The United Kingdom supports calls for greater accountability, including the referral of Afghanistan to the International Court of Justice for violations of the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women.

The Taliban must also recognize the negative impact of their draconian policies on Afghanistan's economic growth and long-term prosperity. As Ms. Bahous highlighted, the Taliban's ban on secondary education for girls is estimated to cost $1.5 billion by 2030.

During the past financial year, the United Kingdom distributed more than $230 million in assistance to the Afghan people. Last week, in partnership with the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations, we announced a new food security initiative, responding to climate-related challenges through the delivery of drought-resistant seeds and more nutritious crops, improved irrigation and training in sustainable farming practices. Half a million Afghans are set to benefit from this United Kingdom-funded programme. The United Kingdom has also continued to engage constructively with the United Nations-led process, including the comprehensive approach.

But reliance on humanitarian assistance is not sustainable in the long term. And the United Kingdom's continued engagement in a process in which the Taliban are not fully committed or willing to take meaningful steps towards meeting their international obligations is not guaranteed. We therefore urge the Taliban to reverse course and demonstrate their readiness to work towards an Afghanistan at peace with itself, its neighbours and the international community.

Ms. Lassen (Denmark): I too thank Special Representative Otunbayeva, Assistant Secretary-General Msuya and UN-Women Executive Director Bahous for their briefings.

Allow me to focus on three areas.

First, the Taliban's repressive policies continue to undermine and deny the people of Afghanistan their basic human rights through policies that affect every aspect of human life, from playing chess to singing. Nothing seems too small for the Taliban regime to control, and that is, of course, particularly true for women and girls.

Restrictive laws, such as the virtue and vice law, seek not only to constrain but to erase women and girls from Afghan society, gravely affecting their fundamental freedoms and society as a whole. As we heard this morning, the ban on access to secondary and higher education has entered its fourth year, meaning that four full grades of girls have had something — which all of us in this Chamber and countries around the world take for granted — interrupted, namely, going to school and learning, even after the age of 12. That is generational damage, as Executive Director Bahous stated.

Denmark resolutely condemns those restrictive policies. They serve only to institutionalize an extreme system of sexual and gender-based discrimination and persecution.

The Taliban controlled judicial system not only restricts Afghans' access to justice and protection but further cements a system of discrimination and oppression. We call on the Taliban to immediately rescind all discriminatory policies and to uphold Afghanistan's obligations under international law, including the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women and Security Council resolutions.

Secondly, as Assistant Secretary-General Msuya made painfully clear this morning, those policies are being implemented against the backdrop of a deepening humanitarian crisis. Even after the United Nations' hyperprioritization exercise, 12.5 million people still require urgent assistance, with nearly 15 million at emergency levels of food insecurity and malnutrition. Yet, despite those mounting needs, cuts in funding are forcing aid agencies to scale back programmes. From food assistance to healthcare and protection services for women and children, it is the most vulnerable who continue to suffer first and most.

We call on the international community to scale up funding for the humanitarian response plan which, as we heard, remains drastically underfunded. For those organizations working to help the Afghan people, the Taliban's diversion of vital aid further hinders their work, putting more lives at risk. Three hundred humanitarian-access-related incidents, from January to April alone, is simply unacceptable. We call on the Taliban to facilitate unhindered humanitarian access to those in need and abide by the obligations of Afghanistan under international law.

Finally, on the political front, Denmark supports the Doha process and welcomes United Nations efforts to develop a political road map. Women's meaningful and safe participation in all diplomatic efforts is imperative for United Nations-facilitated processes — that should go without saying. We encourage the broadening of those processes to ensure the participation of Afghanistan's vibrant and active civil society and individuals of diverse ethnic, religious and gender backgrounds. The Doha process should remain firmly anchored in the recommendations of the United Nations Special Coordinator through a conditions-based, step-for-step approach. Any normalization of engagement with the Taliban must be based on demonstrated measurable and independently verified improvements in human rights, especially for women and girls.

Denmark reaffirms our support for the important work undertaken by the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan. Under difficult circumstances, the mission continues to deliver on its mandate.

In conclusion, as stated in the Secretary-General's report (S/2025/372), the Taliban is purposely implementing policies that are negatively affecting the economic, social and personal lives of the Afghan population. That any Government would want to do that is beyond comprehension.

Let me underscore Denmark's steadfast commitment to the rights and aspirations of the people of Afghanistan. We will continue to support their efforts to achieve the inclusive, just and prosperous future they deserve.

Mr. Bonnafont (France) (*spoke in French*): I would first like to thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General, Ms. Roza Otunbayeva, the Under-Secretary-General for Humanitarian Affairs, Ms. Joyce Msuya, and the Executive Director of United Nations-Women, Ms. Sima Bahous, for their briefings on the situation in Afghanistan. In that regard, I would like to express France's gratitude to the United Nations staff in Afghanistan, both political and humanitarian staff.

Nearly four years ago, the Council adopted resolution 2593 (2021), which set out five demands from the international community for the Taliban. I will recall them, as they are clear and still valid.

First, the Taliban must fight all terrorist groups present on Afghan territory, in particular Da'esh, Al-Qaida and their affiliates.

Secondly, they must combat drug trafficking, including synthetic drugs, the production of which is increasing.

Thirdly, they must establish an inclusive political process to pave the way towards peace and national reconciliation.

Fourthly, they must guarantee respect for the fundamental rights and freedoms of all the Afghan population. That means re-establishing the right of women and girls to education, freedom of movement, action and expression.

Fifthly, they must ensure rapid, safe and unhindered access for all humanitarian actors, including international non-governmental organizations, whose work is critical.

The briefings we just heard confirm the accounts we continue to receive from many Afghan stakeholders. There has been no notable progress in the implementation of the Council's demands. On the contrary, almost four years after the Taliban forcefully took power, there has been an alarming deterioration in the human rights situation. The Taliban regime is continuing its persecution against Afghan women and girls and its systematic violations of their rights. The closure of schools for more than three years and restrictions on their freedom of movement and expression amount to segregation. The daily lives of Afghan women are also marked by growing insecurity.

Furthermore, France is very concerned about the recent aggressions and threats against several United Nations personnel in Kabul. Those unacceptable acts of intimidation are a direct consequence of the policy of segregation implemented by the Taliban. Those attacks on United Nations staff must be investigated fully.

Moreover, terrorist groups, including Da'esh-Khorasan and Al-Qaida, continue to operate from within Afghanistan. The reports of the Monitoring Team of the Security Council Committee established pursuant to resolution 1267 (1999) concerning Afghanistan highlight the ineffectiveness of the Taliban's policies to

curb that threat. France calls on the Taliban to stop tolerating the presence of those groups. Any Government would be required to do likewise.

Despite the ban on opium cultivation, drug trafficking remains widespread in the country, with an increase, as I said, in the production of synthetic drugs. Furthermore, the Taliban have taken no steps towards establishing an inclusive political process. France calls for an end to reprisals against and arbitrary detentions of opponents and for the launch of a genuine intra-Afghan dialogue.

Finally, on the economic front, the Taliban's repressive policies are hindering any prospects for sustainable development in the country. France calls on the Taliban to put in place an economic policy that benefits all Afghan men and women. That begins with restoring women's access to education and employment. The country cannot be kept on life support indefinitely.

The oppression of the Afghan people by the Taliban regime cannot be ignored by the Council. That policy has a destabilizing impact on the region, which is affected by drug trafficking, mass migration movements and the activities of terrorist groups. The Council must therefore continue to address the situation in Afghanistan. The international community's dialogue with the Taliban has yet to yield any results. Unfortunately, the strategy of small steps launched at the third Doha meeting a year ago has not proven equal to the challenge. France accepts political dialogue, but it must be open to all parties and address all issues, not only those in which the Taliban have an interest. The Council must adopt a consistent and structured framework to ensure regional peace and stability, guarantee the rights of Afghan women and men and promote a safe and sustainable future for Afghanistan.

France reiterates its support for the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan and United Nations agencies on the ground. France calls for the appointment of a special envoy, as requested in the relevant resolution (resolution 2721 (2023)), to conduct a comprehensive political dialogue for the benefit of all the Afghan population, in full compliance with international law and international humanitarian law.

France will not abandon Afghanistan and the Afghan people and will continue to provide essential humanitarian aid based on an approach that is by and for women, in accordance with the principles of humanity, neutrality, impartiality and independence.

Mr. Hwang (Republic of Korea): I would like to extend my gratitude to Special Representative of the Secretary-General Otunbayeva for her comprehensive briefing. My delegation appreciates the dedicated work of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA), which remains central to the international community's pursuit of peace and stability in Afghanistan. I also commend Executive Director Sima Sami Bahous and Assistant Secretary-General Joyce Msuya for bringing attention to the harsh reality confronting the Afghan people.

Today I would like to make the following points.

First, the scale of displacement and returnees is alarming. From January to April, more than 400,000 people — approximately 1 per cent of the total population — returned to Afghanistan. While we recognize the decades-long socioeconomic burden borne by neighbouring countries that have hosted Afghan refugees, the principle of voluntary, safe and dignified refugee return must be upheld. At the same time, during the first quarter of 2025 alone, another 400,000 individuals were displaced by climate- and disaster-related events. Relocation and reintegration challenges are mounting rapidly. Food and water insecurity are widespread, and resources are becoming increasingly scarce. The international community must stand by those Afghans who are striving to rebuild their lives from the ground up.

The Republic of Korea has been supporting the vital work of the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees and the International Organization for Migration in Afghanistan in that regard. In addition, we plan to collaborate with United Nations agencies this year to provide emergency livelihood opportunities for women, internally displaced persons and returnees and to help to rehabilitate local water and agricultural infrastructure.

Secondly, Afghanistan's much-needed reconstruction and economic recovery are closely interlinked with respect for human rights and fundamental freedoms. UNAMA reports that the impacts of the so-called Law on the Propagation of Virtue and the Prevention of Vice are reverberating across Afghan society and businesses. Meanwhile, a World Bank study estimates that the ban on girls' education will cost the Afghan economy $1.4 billion per year. Moreover, those policy choices by the Taliban remain a fundamental obstacle to development cooperation for many international donors.

The inclusion and participation of women and girls is not just a human rights imperative. It is a prerequisite for economic development. It is deeply regrettable that we continue to see no signs of improvement on that front. Reports of threats against Afghan women who are United Nations staff simply for going to work are deeply troubling. We reiterate the Council's unanimous call in resolution 2681 (2023) upon the Taliban to swiftly reverse the policies and practices that restrict the rights and freedoms of women and girls.

My third point concerns the Doha process. As we await the initial proposal for a comprehensive political road map from the Department of Political and Peacebuilding Affairs and UNAMA, it is time for Member States to renew their political commitment to that United Nations-led initiative. Sequencing and pairing reciprocal steps between Afghanistan and the international community will be a difficult undertaking. Only through coordinated engagement among various actors can we sustain the momentum of that important process. In that context, we strongly hope that ongoing regional economic engagements with Afghanistan remain compatible and create synergy with the United Nations-led Doha process. The Security Council must pay heed to those developments and provide the necessary political guidance.

Afghanistan is viewed through diverse lenses: as a vital crossroads for regional connectivity; as a source of transnational threats, such as terrorism and narcotics; and as the setting in which international efforts to protect the rights of women and girls are being severely tested. Yet, we believe and hope that the situation in Afghanistan still presents more opportunities for international cooperation than it does for division. As a Security Council Member and a Doha participant, the Republic of Korea stands ready to contribute to discussions aimed at identifying clear benchmarks for a viable political road map. In the meantime, our life-saving support for the people of Afghanistan will continue.

Mr. Alfaro de Alba (Panama) (*spoke in Spanish*): Let me begin by thanking the Special Representative of the Secretary-General, Ms. Roza Otunbayeva, for her presentation of the report (S/2025/372); Ms. Joyce Msuya — whom I cannot see very well because she is on the other side of the camera — Assistant Secretary-General for Humanitarian Affairs and Deputy Emergency Relief Coordinator; and Ms. Sima Sami Bahous, Executive Director of UN-Women, for their detailed briefings. We convey our greetings to the representative of Afghanistan.

We also commend the work being done on the ground by the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) team, which is operating in particularly complex and challenging conditions. The implementation of the so-called Law on the Propagation of Virtue and the Prevention of Vice has had devastating effects on the personal, social and economic lives of the Afghan people, particularly the millions

of women and girls. The report published by UNAMA on 10 April 2025 documents in detail the negative consequences of that law, and we concur with the report's conclusion, namely, that a governance model that excludes women is not sustainable. We reiterate that any aspiration to internal stability must be founded on respect for fundamental rights and the equal participation of all sectors of society. In that connection, we echo the Special Representative's call for all decisions prohibiting women's and girls' access to education at all levels for the fourth consecutive academic year to be rescinded. We respect, and concur with, the position of the Organization of Islamic Cooperation that to deny women and girls access to education does not reflect an Islamic value, and we regard their full inclusion in public life as essential to rebuilding the country's institutions and social fabric.

Afghanistan's economic situation reflects a persistent contradiction. Despite some signs of macroeconomic stability, social indicators point to a continuing deterioration, affecting the well-being of the population and holding it back. Poverty, unemployment and livelihood insecurity afflict a significant portion of the population, especially women and rural communities. Shrinking opportunities and fiscal challenges have had a noticeable impact on service delivery and social cohesion. That state of affairs has led to cuts of up to 30 per cent in the workforce in key sectors such as health and education and 20 per cent in the security sector, directly affecting the provision of public services and the country's internal stability. It is crucial that international efforts — both bilateral and multilateral — promote the reinforcement of those critical capacities.

Panama also wishes to underline the importance of stepping up humanitarian demining efforts in the country — an issue that continues to take a heavy toll on children and directly impedes development. We acknowledge the joint efforts of UNAMA and UN-Women in response to restrictions on access to healthcare and their effects on women and girls. Those efforts must be expanded, as must cooperation with other United Nations agencies.

As to security matters, we are concerned about the rise in attacks perpetrated by the Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan, especially against civilians. The situation demands a coordinated response that includes strengthening mechanisms for technical cooperation among actors on the ground. We reiterate that the protection of United Nations personnel is an absolute and non-negotiable priority. Panama condemns all acts of intimidation and violence against humanitarian personnel and calls for the conditions necessary for them to operate to be fully respected.

When it comes to the political process, Panama stresses the importance of moving towards a multilateral road map such as the proposal set out in the independent assessment requested by the Council through resolution 2679 (2023), the follow-up to which was endorsed through resolution 2721 (2023). We acknowledge UNAMA's endeavours in that regard, in particular through its regional offices, which have forged significant ties with community leaders, entrepreneurs, journalists, youth and women activists in favour of a more structured and coherent framework. We value the precedent set by the resolution of community disputes through local mediation mechanisms as exemplifying the potential for fostering context-based and culturally rooted dialogue processes.

Panama also wishes to acknowledge the role of the countries of Central Asia in promoting regional stability. We commend their commitment to preventive diplomacy and highlight the efforts of the United Nations Regional Centre for Preventive Diplomacy for Central Asia, in particular in areas such as water management, climate cooperation and conflict prevention. In our view, greater coordination between the United Nations Regional Centre for Preventive Diplomacy for Central Asia and the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan could bolster multilateral efforts towards peace and sustainable development in Afghanistan and in its immediate

vicinity. Against a backdrop of mounting geopolitical tensions, Afghanistan must not become a secondary driver of conflict. This juncture marks an opportunity to strengthen early-warning and risk-analysis mechanisms to promote regional stability.

Lastly, we take note of ongoing efforts to convene a meeting of the Doha process in the near future. We trust that that forum will reiterate the need for the international system to have a shared vision for Afghanistan that has human rights at its core and promotes the involvement of civil society actors.

Panama reaffirms its support for UNAMA and the entire United Nations system in the country. It is our firm belief that the international community must act with resolve, consistency and, above all, empathy. Afghanistan cannot be a forgotten cause. The principles of the Charter must be applied with equal conviction the world over. This is not a test for Afghanistan, but a test of the extent to which we are willing to uphold our principles.

Mr. Nebenzia (Russian Federation) (*spoke in Russian*): We would like to thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General and Head of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA), Ms. Roza Otunbayeva, the Assistant Secretary-General for Humanitarian Affairs, Ms. Joyce Msuya, and the Head of UN-Women, Ms. Sima Sami Bahous, for their briefings on the situation in Afghanistan. We are pleased to see representatives from the region also participating in today's discussion.

The Russian Federation consistently supports the activities of UNAMA within the remit given to the Mission. We note Kabul's interest in maintaining and fostering contacts with the Mission. We have taken note of the Secretary-General's report on the situation in Afghanistan (S/2025/372). We would like to make the following points.

For some years now, the Security Council has been discussing the situation in Afghanistan. Contrary to our Western colleagues' forecasts of the inevitable domestic political and economic collapse of Afghanistan, which, for years, had lived off of international aid and is now confronting unprecedented unilateral sanctions and a humanitarian crisis, the country has nonetheless survived and not become a black hole. The de facto authorities are consistently strengthening regional cooperation, with an emphasis on restoring the country's socioeconomic potential without reliance on Western aid. That said, it is clear that, given the magnitude of the threats and the problems that have accumulated in 20 years of war and in the aftermath of the shameful retreat of United States and NATO troops, it will be difficult for the country to swiftly get on the path to independent development. Its long-suffering people need our sustained and non-politicized assistance and support more than ever.

The Russian Federation has consistently advocated a realistic and comprehensive approach to Afghanistan and continues to do so. We have repeatedly underscored that such an approach draws on an objective analysis and a balanced assessment of the situation. The imperative remains the same: constructive and pragmatic engagement by the international community on the Afghan issue, with an emphasis on taking the needs of Afghan people themselves fully on board, rejecting narrow interests and double standards and engaging in patient dialogue with the de facto authorities on all pressing issues. There was, is and will be no alternative to that. Any pressure or blackmail is a road to nowhere. We are delighted that regional players, first and foremost the participants in the Moscow format, concur with our position. Contact among Russia, China, Iran and Pakistan on Afghanistan is further confirmation of that. We see that the Taliban themselves, who agreed to join the United Nations-sponsored Doha process in June 2024, remain interested in developing such engagement with the international community. That is borne out by, among other factors, their participation in the working groups on counter-narcotics and private

sector issues organized by UNAMA, which are set to meet in Doha on 30 June and 1 July.

Against that backdrop, it is regrettable that some Western donors remain stubbornly unwilling to acknowledge their own mistakes and face the consequences. While a number of pragmatic Western colleagues have already understood the futility of trying to make the Taliban dance to their tune and are moving towards resuming broad humanitarian assistance and development, others continue to address the de facto authorities in the language of ultimatums, to maintain artificial impediments and to refuse to return foreign assets stolen from the Afghan people. Not only will such an approach not lead to realistic solutions that can truly improve the situation in Afghanistan and build trust, but it also will not help ordinary Afghans, including women, girls and children, despite the fact that the importance of supporting such groups is something that they constantly shout about from the rooftops. However, that approach has nothing to do with real assistance in resolving the Afghan issue. After all, if those assets were unfrozen, they could be used to build hospitals, schools and roads.

We share the Secretary-General's assessment regarding the complex domestic political situation in Afghanistan. We remain particularly concerned about the security threats posed by the continued terrorist activity by the Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan. We note the efforts being undertaken by the de facto authorities, but we see that those measures are, unfortunately, insufficient. Terrorists continue to increase their influence in the country and intentionally destabilize the situation by carrying out new terrorist attacks and recruiting new members. Their intentions in doing so are clear to us: they are trying to establish themselves as an alternative force and undermine stability in Afghanistan and the region. The fighters themselves confirm that the terrorist groups are being funded from abroad and that they have foreign terrorist fighters in their ranks, including those who gained combat experience in Syria and Iraq and have been transferred to Afghanistan from hot spots. Given the amount of weaponry left by Western military forces in the country, the risks of those weapons falling into the hands of fighters and their spread beyond the region is becoming very real. There is also a threat of terrorist activity spilling over into Central Asia and beyond.

Drug trafficking is another pressing issue closely related to terrorism. The efforts undertaken by the Taliban are insufficient. It is imperative to ensure comprehensive international and regional cooperation on this matter, including through the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. Particular attention needs to be paid to the threat of synthetic drugs manufacturing. Another important issue is providing support for Afghan farmers.

Among our priorities is the socioeconomic situation in the country. We commend the efforts being undertaken by the United Nations and regional organizations to provide humanitarian assistance. We would like to underscore in particular the selfless work being carried out by humanitarian agencies and their staff, who are ready to remain on the ground and assist the Afghan people under any circumstances. At the same time, we regret that attempts by humanitarian workers to expand assistance beyond basic needs are being blocked by a number of Western donors who categorically refuse to help ensure the country's development, restoring civilian infrastructure and building roads connecting provinces and cities with rural areas.

Russia systematically has been providing targeted assistance to those in need in Afghanistan. We are broadening bilateral cooperation in the trade and economic spheres, promoting the development of business dialogue and opportunities, and we are consistently including our Afghan colleagues in international economic forums such as the Russia-Islamic World: KazanForum and the Saint Petersburg International Economic Forum.

We are also focusing on the development of human rights for all Afghans, including women and girls, and the formation of a truly inclusive government with the participation of all ethnic and political groups in the country. We hope to see progress on both tracks.

The Russian Federation fully supports the right and the desire of the Afghan people to live in a peaceful and prosperous country, free from drugs and terrorism. That is the key to order and stability in the region. However, building such a lasting and sustainable peace is impossible without patient engagement with the de facto authorities. It is important that, in international forums, we engage with the Afghans who bear true responsibility for what is happening in the country. We must find a way out of the current impasse and move toward the international reintegration of Afghanistan.

Mr. Ahmad (Pakistan): We would like to commend you, Madam President, and your delegation for your able stewardship of the Council this month.

We take note of the most recent report of the Secretary General (S/2025/372) and thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan and Head of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA), Ms. Roza Otunbayeva, for her comprehensive briefing. We appreciate UNAMA's efforts, under her leadership, to promote normalization in Afghanistan under extremely challenging circumstances. We also thank the Assistant Secretary-General for Humanitarian Affairs, Ms. Joyce Msuya, and the Executive Director of UN-Women, Ms. Sima Sami Bahous, for their valuable complementary briefings.

Nearly four years since the assumption of power by the de facto authorities, the situation in Afghanistan remains precarious. Amid growing global distractions and corresponding reduced attention, the plight of the Afghan people has worsened, marked by crippling sanctions, a dysfunctional banking system, dwindling humanitarian aid, terrorism, narcotics and persistent human rights concerns. While some of those challenges are a legacy of Afghanistan's violent past and others stem from its internal ideological and political dynamics, the truth remains that the international efforts towards normalization have fallen short of what was needed.

The 2025 humanitarian needs and response plan remains critically underfunded, with only 15.7 per cent of the required $2.42 billion secured so far. The international community must fully and unconditionally fund the plan for the sake of the Afghan people's well-being.

Pakistan supports efforts to stabilize Afghanistan's economy, revive its banking system and explore mechanisms for unfreezing Afghan financial assets. Despite our own constraints, Pakistan remains committed to pragmatic engagement in expanding trade and pursuing key regional connectivity initiatives, such as the Turkmenistan-Afghanistan-Pakistan-India gas pipeline; the Central Asia South Asia Electricity Transmission and Trade Project, known as CASA-1000; and the Uzbekistan-Afghanistan-Pakistan railway.

As noted in the Secretariat-General's report, Pakistan is Afghanistan's top export destination and a major source of imports. We have had sustained high-level engagement with the de facto authorities throughout the year. Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister, Mr. Mohammad Ishaq Dar, visited Kabul on 19 April. And in May we had a successful trilateral dialogue with Afghanistan and China at the Foreign Minister level in Beijing to advance mutually beneficial cooperation among our three countries. Just yesterday, our Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister met with the acting Afghan Foreign Minister on the sidelines of the Organization of Islamic Cooperation conference in Istanbul. We also support the various regional forums, such as the Moscow format and the meeting of Foreign Ministers of Afghanistan's neighbouring countries.

We welcome the United Nations efforts, including the Doha process, aimed at structured engagement with the de facto authorities. Pakistan was among the first to call for sustained engagement and has proposed a broad road map for normalization.

A comprehensive and inclusive framework is now urgently needed, one that also addresses regional concerns, as identified in the independent assessment report (S/2023/856, annex).

We hope to get a detailed plan of action for the mosaic approach that has been proposed by the United Nations. Any such plan must pay equal attention to all the issues in a balanced manner.

Afghanistan's internal challenges continue to spill over into the region. Pakistan has hosted millions of Afghans for decades. Since August 2021, an additional 1 million undocumented individuals have crossed into Pakistan, creating, among other issues, law and order concerns. The international community must share that burden more equitably.

We are also concerned about the potential destabilizing impact of the situation in Iran following the unprovoked Israeli attacks. A refugee exodus into neighbouring countries, including Afghanistan and Pakistan, could pose significant new challenges. That might imperil the already fragile situation in Afghanistan.

Terrorism emanating from Afghanistan remains a serious threat to its neighbours, particularly Pakistan. As the report of the Secretary-General notes, the Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan continues to target the de facto authorities. Meanwhile, other terrorist entities, including Al-Qaeda, the Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) and the Baloch militant groups continue to operate from ungoverned spaces in Afghanistan. Afghanistan must not become a safe haven for terrorism against any country.

The TTP, with approximately 6,000 fighters, is the largest United Nations-designated terrorist group operating from Afghan soil. With safe havens close to our border, it directly threatens our national security. As part of our defensive measures, Pakistan has confiscated a significant cache of modern weapons originally left behind by international forces in Afghanistan.

On 27 April, 54 TTP terrorists attempting to infiltrate Pakistan were neutralized by our security forces. That incident underscores the scale and seriousness of the threat.

We also have credible evidence of collaboration between the TTP and other groups, such as the Balochistan Liberation Army and the Majeed Brigade, aimed at disrupting strategic infrastructure and economic development projects in Pakistan.

We reaffirm that the de facto authorities must fulfil their international obligations. We are particularly concerned about the continued restrictions on women and girls, which are inconsistent with both international norms and Islamic traditions. At the International Conference on Girls' Education in Muslim Communities, held under the auspices of the Muslim World League, in January, the Islamabad Declaration reaffirmed the consensus that education for girls was a fundamental human right rooted in Islamic values.

Pakistan continues to support educational opportunities for Afghan youth. The third phase of our Allama Iqbal scholarship programme is currently under way, benefiting 4,500 Afghan students, one third of whom are women.

Pakistan desires a stable, peaceful and prosperous Afghanistan. We remain ready to support international engagement with the de facto authorities. Such engagement must be based on clear objectives, reciprocal steps and a realistic road map sensitive

to Afghanistan's unique social and political fabric, after more than four decades of conflict.

As two immediate neighbours bound by history, geography, ethnicity, language, faith and culture, our destinies are deeply intertwined. Dialogue and diplomacy are the only viable pathways to peace and progress. Pakistan stands committed to playing a constructive and proactive role in helping Afghanistan achieve lasting peace and stability.

Mr. Sekeris (Greece): I would like to thank Special Representative Ms. Otunbayeva, Assistant Secretary-General Ms. Msuya and Executive Director Ms. Bahous for their insightful briefings.

Greece is deeply concerned about the dire humanitarian and human rights situation in Afghanistan.

The month of March marked the beginning of the fourth consecutive school year in which girls beyond the sixth grade are denied access to education. That decision by the Taliban is not only morally unacceptable but it will also have long-term repercussions for the country's economy and society, further marginalizing half of the country's population.

Allow me to make the following three points.

First, Greece strongly condemns human rights violations and abuses against all Afghan citizens, particularly women and girls, who face the most severe restrictions of fundamental freedoms, including freedom of movement and expression and access to healthcare, the labour market and humanitarian assistance.

The stricter implementation of the Law on the Propagation of Virtue and the Prevention of Vice is of grave concern. We denounce all public executions, arbitrary detention and the denials of lawyers' access to detainees. We also call for media freedom and urge the Taliban to end the oppression of journalists and civil society activists.

Secondly, we are particularly concerned by the continued terrorist attacks in Afghanistan and the illicit flow of small arms and light weapons, which result in numerous civilian casualties. We remind the Taliban that countering terrorism is one of their obligations to the international community. We also call on the Taliban to prioritize cleaning unexploded ordnance, which takes the biggest toll on children's lives.

Thirdly, Greece affirms its support for the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan and its proposed road map to foster a more coherent, coordinated and structured engagement between the international community and the Taliban. We believe that the inclusive participation of all segments of Afghan society in that process, including women, civil society representatives and the diaspora, could contribute significantly to its success. At the same time, we reiterate that the normalization of Afghanistan's relations with the international community hinges on the fulfilment of international obligations by the Taliban, particularly the respect for human rights and women's rights and the establishment of an inclusive Government with the full, equal and meaningful participation of women and minorities. We also support the United Nations-led Doha process and believe that the next round of talks could achieve tangible results, especially at the level of the working groups.

In conclusion, let me stress that Greece believes in stability, prosperity and sustainable peace in Afghanistan and reiterates its solidarity with the Afghan people, particularly women and vulnerable groups. The international community should continue to provide needs-based humanitarian assistance to help the country

mitigate the multifaceted crises of poverty, food insecurity, child malnutrition, natural disasters, displacement and the integration of returnees.

At the same time, it is up to the Taliban to engage constructively with the international community for an Afghanistan at peace with itself and its neighbours, fully integrated and meeting its international obligations.

Mr. Geng Shuang (China) (*spoke in Chinese*): I thank Special Representative of the Secretary-General Otunbayeva, Assistant Secretary-General Msuya and Executive Director Bahous for their briefings. I express my appreciation for the work carried out by the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA), the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, UN-Women and other United Nations agencies.

The current situation in Afghanistan is generally stable. The interim Government has made positive efforts in economic development, improving people's livelihoods, combating narcotics and external exchanges, and has made considerable progress. However, the country is still facing multiple challenges, including in the humanitarian situation, development, human rights, terrorist threats and women's rights. The international community should continue to play a constructive role in helping the country to emerge from its difficult situation at an early date.

I wish to share the following points.

First, we must maintain the momentum of dialogue and engagement with the interim Government and continuously enhance mutual understanding and trust. We have taken note of the political road map proposed by UNAMA and we support the mosaic approach to synchronizing efforts to address the concerns of all parties. We hope all parties can set reasonable expectations and discuss the issue in a pragmatic spirit, with a view to putting forward feasible solutions. The Security Council should expeditiously reactivate the package of travel ban exemptions regarding relevant personnel of the interim Government and make timely adjustments to the 1988 sanctions regime, so as to facilitate engagement between the international community and the interim Government.

Secondly, we must increase humanitarian assistance to Afghanistan and translate our concern for the Afghan people into practical action. The Secretary-General's report (S/2025/372) indicated that nearly 23 million people in Afghanistan are in need of humanitarian assistance, but only 15.7 per cent of the humanitarian funding required for this year has been secured. According to Under-Secretary-General for Humanitarian Affairs Tom Fletcher, major donors have drastically reduced their assistance to the country, seriously affecting humanitarian aid on the ground. We call on all traditional donors, especially those who bear a historical responsibility for the current plight in Afghanistan, to stop politicizing and instrumentalizing humanitarian assistance and to immediately resume their financial inputs to Afghanistan, in order to help the Afghan people overcome their current difficulties.

Thirdly, we must provide assistance for Afghanistan's economic reconstruction and help the country embark on the path of self-driven development at an early date. We welcome the meetings under the Doha process of the two working groups on the private sector and counter-narcotics, to be held at the end of the month, and we look forward to more practical results in such areas as microfinancing and crop substitution, so as to better meet the needs of the Afghan people. All parties should continue to help the country enhance its development capacity through bilateral, multilateral and regional cooperation mechanisms, and gradually integrate into the regional and world economy. The countries concerned should immediately lift the unilateral sanctions illegally imposed on Afghanistan, unconditionally return its overseas assets and create the necessary conditions for the development of the Afghan economy and people's livelihoods.

Fourthly, we must urge Afghanistan to uphold women's rights and guide the interim Government in gradually changing its policies. The broader international community expects that the interim Government should give women equal rights to education, employment and participation in public affairs, which will help to maintain social stability and healthy economic development in the country. At the same time, it should also be noted that women's rights and interests do not represent the totality of the Afghan issue, much less the root cause of the current problem. While adhering to international standards, parties should also acquire an understanding of Afghanistan's national conditions and ethnic customs and avoid making excessively high and stringent demands or linking that issue to others, which would, in turn, hamper outside contacts and exchanges with Afghanistan.

Fifthly, we must be resolute in countering terrorism, so as to prevent Afghanistan from once again becoming a hub for terrorist organizations. The international community should encourage and support the interim Government in taking more vigorous actions against all terrorist forces, including Da'esh, Al-Qaeda, the Eastern Turkistan Islamic Movement and Tehrik-e Taliban Pakistan, and at the same time help Afghanistan to develop its economy, improve people's livelihoods and safeguard human rights, so as to eliminate the breeding grounds for terrorism. On counter-terrorism, we must oppose linking terrorism with specific countries or religions; reject double standards, selective approaches and the manipulation of counter-terrorism in the pursuit of geostrategic objectives; and bear firmly in mind the bigger picture of international counter-terrorism cooperation.

Under the leadership of Special Representative of the Secretary-General Otunbayeva, UNAMA has maintained good communication with the interim Government and has coordinated efforts to help the country to meet its multiple challenges, for which China expresses its appreciation. We support UNAMA in continuing to play its bridging role, continuously enhancing exchanges and cooperation with the interim Government and playing a greater role in promoting peace and development in Afghanistan.

In May, the Ministers for Foreign Affairs of China, Afghanistan and Pakistan held an informal meeting in Beijing, jointly sending out a strong message on enhancing political mutual trust, upholding good-neighbourliness and friendship, deepening practical cooperation, combating terrorism and maintaining regional peace and stability. China welcomes the recent announcement by the Government of Pakistan and the interim Government of Afghanistan that they are upgrading their relationship to the ambassadorial level, which is an important step in the implementation of the outcome of the trilateral informal meeting. The second China-Central Asia summit held recently also proposed joining hands to help the Afghan people to maintain peace and stability and promote development and prosperity. We are ready to continue to make greater efforts and play a greater role in promoting the realization of long-term peace and stability in the country and its early integration into the international community.

The President: I shall now make a statement in my capacity as the representative of Guyana.

I have the honour to deliver this statement on behalf of the three African members of the Security Council plus (A3+), namely Algeria, Sierra Leone, Somalia and my own country, Guyana. We thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General and Head of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA), Ms. Roza Otunbayeva, Assistant Secretary-General Joyce Msuya of the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, and Executive Director of UN-Women Sima Sami Bahous for their briefings.

The A3+ reiterates its firm commitment to the sovereignty, independence, territorial integrity and national unity of Afghanistan and reaffirms its unwavering solidarity with the Afghan people. The people of Afghanistan continue to face multifaceted challenges, including widespread poverty and unemployment, persistent security threats, a dire humanitarian crisis and continued restrictions on women and girls. The reduction in international financial assistance has exacerbated the already fragile economic situation. The A3+ is gravely concerned about the impact of funding shortfalls on the provision of humanitarian assistance. A total of 22.9 million people — almost half of the Afghan population — require life-saving support. That is due to persistent food insecurity and malnutrition, population movements, natural disasters and climate change, a strained economy and limited access to basic services. The closure of hundreds of health facilities and nutrition sites has deprived millions of people of access to primary healthcare and life-saving treatment. It is projected that 3.5 million children will experience malnutrition by 2025. We therefore urge international donors and humanitarian partners to scale up contributions.

We are dismayed by the reports of violence against and detention of humanitarian workers, including 13 United Nations personnel. We call on the Taliban to facilitate the unhindered and sustained access to humanitarian aid to all those in need across Afghanistan and to ensure the safety and security of humanitarian personnel.

The A3+ remains deeply concerned that the situation of women and girls in Afghanistan has not improved. They continue to bear the brunt of the Taliban's multiple decrees and of the Law on the Propagation of Virtue and the Prevention of Vice restricting their education, employment, freedom of movement and freedom of expression. We note UNAMA's *Report on the Implementation, Enforcement and Impact of the Law on the Propagation of Virtue and Prevention of Vice in Afghanistan*, published on 10 April, which indicates an increase in restrictions on Afghan people's personal and private spaces and on women's and girls' access to public space and healthcare.

Regrettably, 2025 marks the fourth consecutive year in which the girls and women of Afghanistan have been denied access to education beyond grade six. Afghanistan remains the only country in the world in which girls and women are systematically barred from secondary and higher education. The A3+ reiterates its call on the Taliban to reopen all schools and universities and to swiftly reverse all laws, policies and practices that discriminate against women and girls and infringe upon their human rights and fundamental freedoms. We emphasize that the full, equal and meaningful participation and leadership of women in all spheres of life is necessary for Afghanistan's development and prosperity. The continued denial of the rights of women and girls by the Taliban is driving donor countries' restrictions on development and technical assistance. Ensuring the well-being of the Afghan people must remain at the centre of all efforts.

The security situation in Afghanistan remains of deep concern, with continued attacks by terrorist groups, including Islamic State of Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan, which is reported to have claimed responsibility for the attack in Kunduz City and on the premises of the Ministry of Urban Development and Housing in Kabul. We reiterate our call on the Taliban to scale up efforts to combat terrorism, and we urge countries in the region to intensify joint efforts to stabilize the security situation in Afghanistan and the wider region. In that regard, we note the engagement with neighbouring countries. We welcome UNAMA's effort to develop a risk reduction framework for small arms and light weapons in order to address the threats from illicit arms flows in Afghanistan and the region. We are alarmed that hundreds of children were killed and maimed as a result of unexploded ordnance in 2024. We note the

significant reduction of mine action teams due to funding constraints and urgently call for increased support for unexploded ordnance clearance and risk education.

The A3+ reiterates that engagement between Afghanistan and the international community is crucial for the country's sustainable peace and stability and social and economic development. We note the upcoming meeting of two working groups, on counter-narcotics and the private sector as part of confidence-building measures, coming out of the Doha process. We also take note of the continued engagement of the Secretariat and UNAMA with Afghans and international stakeholders towards a more coordinated and structured multilateral engagement between the international community and the Taliban. We emphasize that that engagement with Afghans must be grounded in inclusivity. We call upon the Taliban to comply with Afghanistan's international obligations for the well-being of all Afghans.

In conclusion, the A3+ reaffirms its full support for UNAMA and Special Representative of the Secretary-General Otunbayeva.

I resume my functions as President of the Council.

I now give the floor to the representative of Afghanistan.

Mr. Faiq (Afghanistan): I thank you, Madam President, for convening this important meeting on the situation in Afghanistan. We congratulate and commend you on your excellent leadership of the Council throughout the month of June. We also thank Special Representative Otunbayeva, Assistant Secretary-General Msuya and Executive Director Bahous for their compelling and informative briefings. We extend our sincere appreciation to the members of the Council, regional and international partners, United Nations funds and programmes, non-governmental organizations and donor countries for their continued, consistent and principled support for the people of Afghanistan, particularly in addressing the dire situation of women and girls, including refugees and returnees, and for their efforts in meeting urgent humanitarian and basic needs.

Nearly four years since the Taliban's return to power, under a non-inclusive, repressive and non-legitimate regime, the people of Afghanistan, amid despair and uncertainty, continue to endure one of the world's most severe human rights and humanitarian crises. The absence of formal conflict should not obscure the gravity of the suffering on the ground. The population lives under deepening repression, widespread poverty and the systematic dismantling of rights, especially in the case of women and girls.

The latest report of the Special Rapporteur on the situation of human rights in Afghanistan (A/HRC/58/80) confirms that, since August 2021, the Taliban have institutionalized systemic, gender-based discrimination, excluding women and girls from public life and dismantling the legal and civil institutions that once protected their rights. The Secretary-General's report (S/2025/372) further underscores the devastating impact of the Taliban's so-called Law on the Propagation of Virtue and the Prevention of Vice, which has entrenched a framework of authoritarian control across all sectors of Afghan society. That law not only restricts fundamental freedoms — freedom of movement, expression and belief — but has effectively criminalized everyday life, especially for women. Afghan women are denied access to education, barred from employment in most sectors and excluded from all public and political spaces. Their freedom of movement is curtailed, their voices silenced and their presence in society erased. Afghanistan remains the only country in the world in which girls are banned from secondary and higher education. Four academic years have now passed, with no pathway forward for Afghan girls. That is a moral and strategic failure, which must not be normalized. The future of Afghanistan cannot be built while half of its population is locked out of learning, decision-making and opportunity.

Those egregious violations stand in stark contradiction to Afghanistan's national interests and its social and economic prosperity, and they demand urgent action from the international community. That includes exerting pressure on the Taliban to reverse their discriminatory policies through existing tools and accountability mechanisms such as the Committee on the Elimination of Discrimination against Women, the implementation of the relevant Security Council and General Assembly resolutions and the imposition of targeted sanctions. Moreover, recognizing and codifying gender apartheid as a crime under international law is essential to ensuring justice, accountability and the protection of women's rights in Afghanistan and beyond.

The United Nations has rightly acknowledged that political progress and inclusive governance are indispensable for Afghanistan's future. In that context, we welcome the renewed efforts under the auspices of the United Nations in support of a comprehensive approach based on the recommendations of the independent assessment mandated by the Council. In that context, we take note of the draft concept for the mosaic approach. However, serious concerns remain. The draft mosaic approach, as it stands, lacks genuine Afghan ownership. Afghan democratic forces, political actors, civil society, women's organizations and youth representatives have not been meaningfully consulted in its development. The process has been perceived by many as top-down and non-participatory, undermining its credibility and legitimacy. If the proposed draft mosaic framework is to serve as a pathway towards national reconciliation and international reintegration, it must be transformed into an inclusive, transparent and accountable process. The people of Afghanistan, who have long defended democracy, human rights and pluralism, must be at the centre of this effort, not relegated to the margins.

We are also concerned about the imbalance in expectations. The Taliban's demands, such as formal recognition, the unfreezing of assets and sanctions relief, are clear and time-bound. In contrast, the international community's and the Afghan people's expectations regarding human rights, inclusivity and governance are vague, non-conditional and lack enforceable benchmarks. That asymmetry risks the normalization of Taliban rule, without meaningful reform or accountability. We therefore urge the United Nations and all international stakeholders to adopt the following principles in any future deliberations.

A participatory and inclusive process must be ensured, including by establishing a well-defined and structured platform that reflects the collective voice of non-Taliban Afghan stakeholders, empowering them to shape both the content and the direction of political dialogue. Afghan women and civil society must be elevated as core actors in all working groups and decision-making structures — not as symbolic participants but as full partners. Clear, measurable and time-bound benchmarks must be defined for Taliban compliance, linked to conditional international engagement. The political process and inclusive governance must be prioritized as the central enablers of peace, stability and international reintegration. The United Nations must facilitate a broader intra-Afghan dialogue that includes credible non-Taliban democratic actors, opposition groups and civil society organizations, including women-led initiatives and youth representatives. A United Nations special envoy must be appointed to coordinate inclusive intra-Afghan dialogue and unify international efforts under United Nations auspices.

Afghanistan's humanitarian crisis is deeply concerning. As the Assistant Secretary-General reported, more than 22 million Afghans needs life-saving assistance, yet funding shortfalls have forced health facilities to close, food assistance to be scaled down and protection services to disappear. The impact on women and girls is especially severe, with aid operations unable to hire or reach them, owing to Taliban restrictions. We must not allow a funding crisis to compound an existing man-made political and human rights catastrophe. We urge all donors to urgently

step up and ensure that humanitarian aid remains principled, predictable and gender-responsive.

The situation of Afghan refugees and returnees from neighbouring countries is worsening and is especially marked by uncertainty and forced deportations. Returnees face severe hardship owing to a lack of identity documents and access to basic services. Urgent international action is needed to uphold the rights, dignity and protection of those refugees and Afghan returnees.

The Taliban continue to govern without inclusion, legitimacy or respect for the Afghan people's will. Reports of public executions, arbitrary arrests, extrajudicial killings and torture are profoundly disturbing and run contrary to all international norms and obligations. The Taliban's suppression of media freedom, closure of civic space and refusal to honour their own amnesty for former government personnel are a further breach of trust.

There are also grave concerns about the growing threats posed by terrorism. As highlighted in the latest report of the Analytical Support and Sanctions Monitoring Team (see S/2025/71), more than two dozen terrorist groups are now operating within Afghanistan. The alarming proliferation of so-called jihadi madrasas across the country is exacerbating those risks; they are serving as breeding grounds for radicalization and recruitment. Those developments continue to fuel instability within Afghanistan and pose a serious threat to regional and international peace and security.

Afghanistan's reintegration into the international community cannot proceed under a regime that systematically violates international law, marginalizes its citizens and obstructs all paths to a peaceful political solution. There must be no impunity for those grave violations. We therefore call for the activation of appropriate international accountability mechanisms, including the International Court of Justice and the International Criminal Court, to address crimes under international law, in particular gender persecution and other serious human rights abuses.

In conclusion, we urge the Security Council to act with urgency and resolve. The future of Afghanistan must not be dictated by force, exclusion or fear. It must be shaped through inclusive dialogue, genuine accountability and a shared commitment to the rights, dignity and aspirations of all Afghans, especially the women and girls who have borne the brunt of the crisis.

The United Nations has a pivotal role to play. But that role must be principled, not permissive; inclusive, not imposed; and grounded in the values that brought this Organization into being: peace, justice and human rights for all.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of India.

Mr. Parvathaneni (India): I thank Special Representative of the Secretary-General and Head of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA), Ms. Roza Otunbayeva, for her briefing today. Our delegation also notes the comments made by Assistant Secretary-General Joyce Msuya and UN-Women Executive Director Sima Bahous.

India and Afghanistan share a special relationship rooted in civilizational and historical ties. That enduring bond forms the foundation of our close engagement with the Afghan people and shapes our broader approach towards Afghanistan.

We believe that international and regional consensus and cooperation on key issues concerning Afghanistan are essential. Accordingly, India is actively engaging with the regional and international parties to promote peace, stability and development in the country. Our participation in the United Nations meetings in Doha and other regional forums reflect our ongoing efforts in that direction. India

has also been an active participant in the two UNAMA working groups on counter-narcotics and enabling the private sector in Afghanistan. And we look forward to participating in the upcoming round of those meetings, scheduled to be held later this month in Doha.

In May, the External Affairs Minister of India spoke with the acting Foreign Minister of Afghanistan, Mr. Mawlawi Amir Khan Muttaqi. During the exchange, the External Affairs Minister welcomed the strong condemnation of the Pahalgam terrorist attack by the Afghan side. He also reaffirmed the traditional friendship between Indian and Afghan people and reiterated India's continued support for their development needs.

India's immediate priorities in Afghanistan include providing humanitarian assistance and implementing capacity-building initiatives for the Afghan people. We have been working with various United Nations agencies to support the Afghan people in the areas of healthcare, food security, education and sports. Since 2021, India has supplied approximately 50,000 metric tons of wheat, more than 330 metric tons of medicines and vaccines, 40,000 litres of pesticide Malathion and 58.6 metric tons of other social support items, including winter jackets, toys and stationary items for school children and earthquake relief material, to Afghanistan. In partnership with the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, we have supplied 84 metric tons of assistance, including 11,000 units of female hygiene kits, baby food, blankets, clothing and medicines, and 32 metric tons of social support items for Afghan drug rehabilitation programmes, particularly those aimed at women.

In the field of education, India continues to offer scholarships and fellowship schemes for Afghan students. Since 2023, we have provided scholarships for undergraduate and postgraduate courses to 2,000 Afghan students. Notably, nearly 600 Afghan girls and women have availed themselves of those scholarships.

In conclusion, I would like to underline India's historic ties with the people of Afghanistan and its enduring commitment to addressing their needs. At the same time, we remain committed to continuing close engagement with all relevant stakeholders and supporting the international community's efforts towards a stable, peaceful and prosperous Afghanistan.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Qatar.

Ms. Al-Thani (Qatar) (*spoke in Arabic*): We thank you, Madam President, for convening this meeting and giving us the opportunity to take part in it. We express our appreciation to Ms. Roza Otunbayeva, Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan and Head of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA), for her briefing and continued efforts. We also thank Ms. Joyce Msuya, Assistant Secretary-General for Humanitarian Affairs, and Ms. Sima Sami Bahous, Executive Director of UN-Women, for their insightful briefings.

The political, economic and humanitarian situation in Afghanistan compels us all to redouble our collective efforts to support the Afghan people. Achieving security and stability in Afghanistan will have a positive impact on regional and international peace and security.

The State of Qatar initiated the establishment of the Doha peace process for Afghanistan in 2013, in cooperation with international partners, and hosted a series of dialogues as part of an inclusive political process that includes all parts of the Afghan society. Our efforts led to the signing of a peace agreement between the United States and the Taliban in Doha on 29 February 2020, which was described by the Security Council in resolution 2513 (2020) as a significant step towards ending the war and opening the door to intra-Afghan negotiations.

Since then, Qatar has continued to coordinate international efforts and facilitate dialogue among the United Nations, the relevant States and the caretaker Government of Afghanistan. We are proud to host the United Nations-led Doha process on Afghanistan, starting with the meetings of the Special Envoys to Afghanistan, called for by the Secretary-General, in Doha in May 2023, February 2024 and July 2024, with a view to adopting a comprehensive approach in facilitating a principled and more coherent and coordinated international engagement aimed at achieving peace and stability in Afghanistan.

In that context, the State of Qatar looks forward to hosting the third meeting of the working group on counter-narcotics and the second meeting of the working group on the private sector established through the United Nations-led Doha process on Afghanistan, to be held in Doha from 30 June to 1 July, with the participation of the representatives of the caretaker Government of Afghanistan and the States participating in the Doha process, as well as technical experts.

The State of Qatar is continuing its efforts, through the Qatar Fund for Development and in cooperation with United Nations entities, to provide humanitarian support to the Afghan people, including providing food assistance, supporting basic healthcare programmes, improving access to education for Afghan children, providing scholarships, supporting Afghan women's economic empowerment programmes and increasing women's resilience to crises, and supporting Afghan youth empowerment programmes.

In conclusion, the State of Qatar stresses that it will make every effort to support the Afghan people in addressing the multiple challenges they face and supporting them on the path to achieving peace and stability. We will continue working with regional and international partners to consolidate peace and strengthen the foundations of development in Afghanistan.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of the Islamic Republic of Iran.

Mr. Iravani (Islamic Republic of Iran): I thank you, Madam President, for convening this meeting. We thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-Genera for Afghanistan, Ms. Otunbayeva, for her valuable briefing. We also thank Ms. Msuya, Assistant Secretary-General for Humanitarian Affairs, and Ms. Bahous, Executive Director of UN-Women, for their insightful updates.

First, I want to express my deep regret to the Western members of the Security Council, especially the United States, the United Kingdom and France. Even though the briefers at today's briefing warned about the dire impact of Israeli and United States aggression on my country, especially on Afghan refugees and displaced persons, the representatives of those countries did not even say they were concerned. They have shown that they do not truly care about the lives of innocent civilians, humankind or human rights. Even their claims about supporting Afghan women and girls are empty words. It is truly sad to see that hypocrisy and double standard.

The most recent report of the Secretary-General clearly shows the serious hardship faced by the people of Afghanistan — poverty, unemployment, limited basic services, frequent natural disasters and harsh restrictions on women and girls. In the context of the report, I wish to highlight the following points.

First, more than 22.9 million Afghans need urgent help. The humanitarian response plan requires $2.42 billion, yet funding is alarmingly low. Humanitarian aid must remain impartial and unhindered. The international community cannot abandon the Afghan people. It must meet its obligations with sustained generous support.

Secondly, frozen assets and financial restrictions worsen the crisis. Afghanistan's economy cannot recover until its assets are responsibly unfrozen and international financial mechanisms allow vital trade and humanitarian work.

Thirdly, the de facto authorities must honour their counter-terrorism obligations and prevent Afghanistan from becoming a safe haven for the Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan and other extremists. We are seriously concerned that elements of the Islamic State in Iraq and the Sham, especially those of Central Asian nationalities, could transfer from Syria into Afghanistan, deepening insecurity across the region.

Fourthly, Iran continues to host millions of Afghan refugees, despite serious security risks and illegal crossings. Iran cannot shoulder that burden alone. International support is urgently needed for hosts like Iran and Pakistan, and in order to facilitate the return of those refugees to their homeland. In the meantime, we cannot ignore the threat posed by the ongoing Israeli aggression against Iran. Those brutal and barbaric attacks, fully supported by the United States, endanger millions of civilians, including more than 7 million Afghan people living in Iran. Currently, much civilian infrastructure in Iran has been targeted by the criminal Israeli regime, leading to the loss of many civilian lives. The continued Israeli attacks put those civilians, including refugees, at risk and destabilize the region further. In the meantime, we have credible reports that some illegal immigrants have been recruited by Israeli intelligence for operational purposes and terrorist attacks in Iran.

Fifthly, lasting stability depends on an inclusive Government. Women, ethnic minorities and all Afghan groups deserve full political participation. Practical engagement with the de facto authorities must continue and produce a credible road map for reintegration into the international community. The United Nations presence in Afghanistan is vital. Iran joins others in supporting the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan and the Special Representative.

In conclusion, if the Israeli crimes and aggression against Iran continue, with the complicity of the United States and several Western countries, my Government will have no choice but to consider facilitating the safe and prompt return of Afghan nationals to their homeland to protect them from those brutal and savage attacks. That is not a policy Iran desires to pursue. For decades, Iran has generously hosted millions of Afghan refugees, but exceptional security circumstances now leave us no alternative.

The meeting rose at 12.15 p.m.